

NIXON'S WAR

JANUARY 1969–DECEMBER 1971

President Richard Nixon took office in 1969 with the promise to “bring the boys home” without losing South Vietnam to communism. Under the policy of “Vietnamization,” the US trained and equipped South Vietnamese (ARVN) troops to take on a bigger role in the war, and American troop presence was steadily de-escalated. With the burden of fighting handed over to them, the ARVN saw mixed results in battle against the North Vietnamese (NVA) due to poor leadership and morale. Peace talks in Paris soon stalled. Nixon responded by widening the war’s scope: bombing Cambodia and launching cross-border incursions into both Cambodia and Laos. Cambodia, already destabilized by American action, also came under threat from communist Khmer Rouge guerrillas. Meanwhile, in the United States, antiwar protests would increase in scale.